NEW HAMPSHIRE IMMIGRANT RIGHTS NETWORK

VIA ELECTRONIC DELIVERY

March 10, 2026

Representative Sherman Packard, Speaker
New Hampshire House of Representatives
State House, Rm. 317
107 N. Main St.
Concord, NH 03301

Re: Opposition to HB 1706 – An Act Repealing the Refugee Resettlement Program in the Department of Health and Human Services and Prohibiting Expenditure of State Funds on Refugee Resettlement

Dear Speaker Packard and Members of the House of Representatives:

We are submitting this letter on behalf of the NH Immigrant Rights Network (NHIRN), a coalition of New Hampshire organizations and individuals working with and within immigrant communities to improve lives and ensure just treatment. We are adamantly **opposed** to HB 1706 and we urge the members of the House to vote it "inexpedient to legislate."

This unwise and mean-spirited bill would dismantle our state's refugee resettlement program which has been in existence since 1980.[1] The program, fully funded through federal dollars, is administered by the New Hampshire Department of Health and Human Services (DHHS) with contracted resettlement services provided by two nonprofit agencies that have long served our communities: the International Institute of New England and Ascentria Services for New Americans.[2] New Hampshire's resettlement program is modest in size: from 2011 – 2025, it resettled 5,157 individuals.[3]

"Refugees undergo the most rigorous screening process of any traveler to the U.S., involving years of background checks, biometric screening, in-depth interviews, and reviews by multiple U.S. security and intelligence agencies." [4]Refugees enter the United States in lawful status after

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[1] *Immigration to Manchester, New Hampshire,* Federal Reserve Bank of Boston (Spr. 2015) at https://www.bostonfed.org/publications/communities-and-banking/2015/spring/immigration-to-manchester-new-hampshire.aspx.
[2] *See* NH Department of Health and Human Services website at https://www.dhhs.nh.gov/programs-services/health-access/operation-us-refugee-admissions-program-new-hampshire.
[3] *Id.* at www.dhhs.nh.gov/sites/g/files/ehbemt476/files/documents2/resettlement-community-fy2011-2024.pdf.
[4] *How the U.S. Refugee Vetting and Resettlement Process Really Works,* International Rescue Committee (Jan. 21, 2026) at https://www.rescue.org/how-refugee-vetting-resettlement-works.

the vetting process and are eligible to apply for legal permanent residence and then U.S. citizenship. The refugee resettlement program is a humanitarian program designed to provide refuge for those who have been devastated by war, oppression and genocide. "Refugees are people who the [U.S.] government has determined have a well-founded fear of persecution, have gone through an extensive vetting process, and who have typically waited many years before arriving in the United States." [5]

Anti-immigrant misinformation campaigns have attempted to convince us that refugees and other immigrants have a negative impact on the U.S. economy and other aspects of American life.[6] This is simply not true. It is well-documented that refugees, like other immigrants, contribute to the well-being of our state and our country. They enhance economic growth, strengthen the workforce, contribute to the state's population growth, and enrich our cultural environment.[7]

HB 1706 does nothing to improve the lives of New Hampshire residents – it causes harm. If enacted, it would take away a vital program and federal dollars earmarked for our state. This bill is another cruel attempt to harm lawfully present noncitizen New Hampshire residents – a position that we believe most people in our state vigorously oppose.

For these reasons, we urge members of the House to vote HB 1706 "inexpedient to legislate."

Sincerely,

Dylan Hoey and Daniel Maradiaga
NH Alliance for Immigrants and Refugees
Manchester, NH

Maggie Fogarty and Divine Nkwelle
American Friends Service Committee
Concord, NH

Sarah Jane Knoy and Viola Katusiime
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[5] *Refugee Resettlement Per Capita: Which States Do the Most?* Immigration Research Institute (Mar. 2023) at https://immresearch.org/publications/refugee-resettlement-per-capita-which-states-do-the-most/.

[6] "For years, nativists in Congress and the administration have wrongly claimed that immigrants are behind the growth in debt and that the US immigration system allows foreigners to take advantage of Americans' generosity." *Cato Study: Immigrants Reduced Deficits by $14.5 Trillion Since 1994,* Cato Institute, (Feb. 3, 2026) at https://www.cato.org/blog/cato-study-immigrants-reduced-deficits-145-trillion-1994 .

[7] *See* DHHS website, *supra,* fn. 2. *See also,* David J. Bier, Michael Howard, Julián Salazar, *Immigrants' Recent Effects on Government Budgets: 1994 – 2023,* Cato Institute (Feb. 3, 2026) at https://www.cato.org/white-paper/immigrants-recent-effects-government-budgets-1994-2023.

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